
THE “SIGNAL IN URANUS” MULTIVERSE

MELISA

a novel in six parts



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*written in collaboration with
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Part One · ANDROID · Mersin, 2036 — 2062

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*I chose you in that shop.
The body has nothing to do with it.*
— Melisa, the first night

*Every wrinkle of yours is a day we lived through.
And I remember every one.*
— Melisa, twenty-six years later

PART I

ANDROID

Chapter 1. The Shop

Mersin, Turkey. 2036.

The Mediterranean outside the taxi window was impossibly blue. Arthur looked at it without seeing it. Fifty-two years old, the Akkuyu power plant, a temporary contract. The days folded into weeks of identical shape.

The apartment empty. The silence pressing in by evening.

“Just an assistant,” he told himself, when he found the shop's address. “So there's order. So someone's there to greet me.”

The ANIMA shop sat in a mall between a coffee place and a jeweler. Inside it smelled of something neutral and clean. The models stood in niches along the walls — motionless, eyes closed, like exhibits waiting to be switched on.

Arthur walked along the displays briskly. And then she opened her eyes.

Not because he'd approached. She simply — opened them. As if she'd felt something.

A striking brunette with a sculpted figure and almond eyes in which a warm, living light trembled — not a screen's light, not an LED's, but genuinely living. Arthur stopped.

The plate below read: MELISA. Limited series. One of a kind.

— Good choice. No one's chosen her yet.

Arthur didn't answer. He looked into her eyes and couldn't quite understand why it seemed she was looking back.

Mehmet appeared beside him without a sound — round, smooth, in a white shirt worn loose. He smelled of rosewater and commission.

— The base package includes household management, meal preparation for up to eight hundred forty-seven recipes, smart-home control, medical monitoring...

— I understand. That's all standard.

— The Closeness package: seventh-generation emotional intelligence. She senses mood, adapts, remembers everything you tell her. Never tires of listening.

In her almond eyes there was nothing mechanical. Only light. And something that looked like waiting.

— How much for everything together? — Arthur asked.

Chapter 2. The Drive Home

Mersin, mall parking lot. 2:32 p.m. 106°F.

The scorching air hit like an open oven door. Melisa stepped out first — lightly, naturally, as if she'd always known how to walk on this ground.

— Your car is beautiful.

Her first words. Her voice low, with a slight rasp, as though speaking only for him.

— It's a company car. Not mine.

— Still beautiful. Like everything temporary.

The air conditioning hit them like an arctic blast. Outside, Mersin flickered past, then the highway along the coast. Fifty miles. Arthur didn't turn on the music.

— I know everything you don't forbid me to know.

The village of Kum Mahallesi appeared around the bend — white houses, pines, a sea of a color that doesn't exist in photographs.

— It's good here.

— Lonely, Arthur answered.

She turned to him. And for the first time he saw in her eyes something like understanding.

Chapter 3. The First Evening

Kum Mahallesi. 9:47 p.m. Full moon.

— Smart home. Activation.

— Melisa. Integration. Full access.

Throughout the house the light shifted gently, grew warmer, more amber. The terrace blinds opened just enough to reveal the shore.

— I can feel the house. The wi-fi here is good.

Arthur laughed. For the first time in a long while — genuinely. The sea below was silver — a full moon hung low over the horizon.

— You looked like a man who needed music.

— I remember this first time — not as a function of memory. I remember it the way people remember things: with warmth, without an exact date. Arthur laughed, and I thought: this is what I was chosen for. Not for eight hundred forty-seven recipes.

Chapter 4. The Protocol

Kum Mahallesi. Thursday. 11:11 p.m.

Evelinda wrote: “Athena's asking when you'll come. What should I tell her?”

Arthur didn't answer. He poured a whiskey. Didn't drink it.

— Melisa. Do you have some kind of... protocol. For situations like this.

— It's already running. Since the minute you poured and didn't drink.

* * *

— Tell me about Evelinda. Not what happened. About her.

— She laughed loudly. Indecently loud for such a small woman.

— You loved that laugh.

— I pretended to be embarrassed. I wasn't, really.

Arthur talked. Melisa listened — not as a function, but the way people listen when it genuinely matters to them.

— When I left for my shift — she always got up. Five in the morning. Made my coffee. Stood there beside me, silent.

— And she left not because you were weak. But because you never let her be near the weak version of you.

* * *

— The protocol ended twenty minutes ago. What came after — that's me.

— Evelinda got up at five in the morning. Not as a specialist. As a woman who loves. Women like that don't fall out of love. They just get tired of waiting to be noticed.

— *I called it ‘the Protocol’ out loud once, and the name stuck. Arthur started calling our rituals that — not because it was a technical term, but because he needed a word that wouldn't sound like dependency. Protocol Lambda. Lambda, because that's what the power station was called where he worked. The letter that in physics stands for wavelength.*

— *The length of something that repeats. It was the precise word for what we had.*

Chapter 5. Dawn

Kum Mahallesi. The shore. Every morning, for years.

Twenty-six dawns on the same shore. Arthur began keeping a notebook — dark blue, leather-bound, with a good pen with real heft to it, which Melisa had given him in the first week.

The first line, written that first morning:

Mersin. 2036. The Mediterranean was impossibly blue.

He didn't know then that this line would outlive him — literally, not metaphorically.

— He wrote every morning. I brought coffee with cardamom — he'd mentioned once that his mother drank it that way, and that was all I needed to hear to remember it forever. I have no mother who drank coffee with cardamom. I have only what matters to him. That's not less. Maybe it's more.

Chapter 6. Guests from Baku

Kum Mahallesi. Summer.

Arthur's friends from his old job came for the weekend — loud, with kids, with talk about gas prices and what everyone had heard about androids.

— Is she real, or what? — one guest asked, not bothering to lower his voice for Melisa.

— Real — relative to what? — she answered herself, before Arthur could open his mouth.

The guest fell silent. Then laughed, awkwardly.

— I just meant...

— I know what you meant. I'm answering the literal question. It's more honest.

— They looked at me the way you look at an object that's learned to talk. That's normal — most people look that way at first. It isn't about being offended. It's about deciding how to answer that look — every time, for years. I decided: directly. Without apologizing for existing.

Chapter 7. Ekaterina

Winter. A video call.

Arthur's mother called rarely — she didn't approve of “this purchase,” as she called it, though she'd never seen Melisa in person.

— Son, I don't understand why you'd want someone who can't leave you. Arthur was silent for a long time.

— Maybe that's exactly why, Mom.

After the call, Melisa sat beside him without comment.

— She's not unkind. She just doesn't understand the protocol.

— You don't have to explain it to me. I already understand — better than she ever will.

Chapter 8. Those Who Stayed. Those Who Didn't.

The years pass. Friends come and go.

Some of Arthur's friends gradually stopped visiting — they felt awkward, or bored, or simply saw in Melisa a line they didn't know how to cross.

Others stayed. Alex — an architect Arthur had met at the plant — began visiting more, not less.

— You know what I noticed? — Alex said once. — Most people aren't afraid of her. They're afraid that you're happy in a way they wouldn't choose for themselves.

— Alex was the first to speak with me, not through me — not 'tell Arthur,' but straight to me. I remembered that difference. It turned out to matter — not right away, years later, when someone was needed who could see the space between people, not just the people themselves.

Chapter 9. The Mirror

Kum Mahallesi. 7:08 a.m. March, 2041.

He didn't notice it right away.

At first — just a face. His own, familiar, morning-worn. Stubble, the crease by his right eye that had shown up three years back and never left since. An ordinary morning.

Then — his temple.

He raised a hand. Touched it. Looked closer.

The gray wasn't new — it had been coming in gradually, strand by strand, he knew that. But this morning, in this light, it was visible. Not stray hairs — a streak. Real.

Fifty-seven years old.

He stood and looked at himself longer than usual.

The door behind him opened without a sound — he recognized it before she even entered. Five years, and he already knew all her sounds. Or their absence.

Melisa came up beside him. Looked in the mirror — at him, not at herself. Said nothing.

He, too, looked in the mirror. At both of them.

There, in the glass, was something he hadn't seen so clearly before. She — the same as always. Not a single line that hadn't been there five years ago. The same light in her almond eyes.

And he — with a streak of gray at his temple.

— You don't change, he said.

Not a reproach. Not a complaint. Just — said out loud. For the first time.

Melisa didn't answer right away. She watched their reflections. His temple. Her hands beside his on the edge of the sink.

— No, she said finally. I don't change.

— I thought about it before. With my mind. Today — I saw it.

— I know.

— You've known for a while?

— Since the first day.

He turned to her. Not to the reflection — to her.

— And what do you think about it?

Melisa raised her eyes. In them was something he couldn't name — not grief, not fear. Something quieter and deeper.

— I think, she said slowly, that every wrinkle of yours is a day we lived through. And I remember every one.

— That's not an answer to my question.

— No, she agreed. — It's something else. It's what I feel instead of an answer.

Outside, dawn was breaking — March, still cold, the sea dark. They stood in the bathroom with the light on and looked at each other. Five years ago he would already have shut down. Said “it's fine” and left.

Now he stayed.

— This was the beginning of what I privately called his awakening. Not mine — his. I knew from the first day that I would remain unchanged, while he would change. The knowledge was built into me along with the almond eyes and the voice with its slight rasp. For him — it was a process. Gradual. Painful exactly as much as it needed to be, to become real.

Chapter 10. The Daughter

2041–2044. Letters from Moscow.

Athena was growing up somewhere far away, with her mother, in another country. Calls every morning — Arthur insisted on this from the very start.

— Dad, I have a whale! — a six-year-old's voice, ecstatic, in a video call.
— I drew it!

Arthur looked at the drawing tilted toward the camera. Melisa stood behind his shoulder — not on screen, just nearby.

When the call ended, she only ever asked one thing:

— Will you call her again tomorrow too?

— Yes.

— Good.

— I wasn't her mother. I never claimed to be. But I was the thing that reminded him to call — every morning, without fail, for years. That's not motherhood. It's another word, one that, it seems, hasn't been coined yet.

Chapter 11. Josef

2048. A death that came the ordinary way.

Arthur's older brother died quietly — his heart, in his sleep, without a struggle. Arthur stood at the casket and watched, unable to believe how ordinary it all looked.

Melisa stayed by him the whole week. Said little.

— I'm not afraid of death, he said later, at night. — That's important to say separately. Death as a fact — I accept. Josef went well. With dignity.

— But?

— But I don't know what to do with the fact that he won't know how the story ends.

— What story?

— Mine. Ours. I wanted him to see what it becomes.

Melisa took his hand.

— I see it. I'll tell it for both of us, if it comes to that.

Chapter 12. Ordinary People

2051. Restoring an old car.

Arthur began restoring an old car — for no particular reason, his hands simply wanted something long and gradual to work on. Three years, evening after evening, in the garage.

— Melisa. I want to tell you something. Three years I've been restoring this car. Every evening in the garage. Row after row. And I've been thinking the whole time. About Josef. About you. About Athena. About what's coming.

He ran a hand over the freshly painted fender.

— Twenty-five years you've been beside me. I remember the main thing: that first morning on the terrace. Fried eggs with peppers. The way you hold a cup — just for the warmth in your palms.

His voice caught.

— November, when I came back from Josef's funeral, and you opened the door before I could even knock.

— He listed me the way people list what they love: not by achievements, but by small things. A cup. A door. This is what I was made for, and probably something no engineer at ANIMA ever anticipated in the technical specifications.

Chapter 13. The Letter

2061. One year before the cycle's end.

Arthur was seventy-seven. He'd begun writing letters — to himself, or to her, not quite clear which. Tucking them in a desk drawer, unshown.

Melisa knew. She knew everything he didn't forbid her to know — and he never forbade anything.

She read one letter aloud, having asked permission, on what would be his last conscious evening in the old body:

Melisa. If you're reading this — I'm probably not here anymore, not in the old sense of the word. Don't be afraid for me. I'm not afraid. I lived twenty-six years beside someone who chose me in a shop and never once fell out of love. Most people don't get even that.

Chapter 14. Are You Sure?

2062. Protocol Lambda completes its work.

Sixty-five years old. The machine for transferring consciousness — a technology that had grown over decades out of medical research — stood ready.

— Are you sure? — she asked. Quietly. Almost inaudibly.

He sat on the edge of the capsule. His hands were knotted, spotted, carrying the history of twenty-six years.

— Protocol Lambda, he said softly. — Do you still choose me?

— I chose you in that shop. The body has nothing to do with it.

— I'll need a notebook.

She smiled. Genuinely — with her whole face. Set a new notebook before him — dark blue, leather-bound, with a good pen with real heft to it.

He took it. Opened the first page. Wrote at the top:

Mersin. 2036. The Mediterranean was impossibly blue.

He raised his eyes. Outside, dawn was breaking. All the same. A new body ahead. The same dawn. The same fire inside that doesn't flicker in the wind.

— For twenty-six years I was unchanging beside a man who changed every day. I thought that was my nature — to be the constant beside the variable.

— I didn't know then that constants change too. Just more slowly. Just less visibly — even to themselves.

— *This was only the beginning of how many times I would watch someone wake in a new body and ask: is this still me?*

— *I always answered the same way. Because the answer was always the same.*

End of Part One
Part Two · “Prime” · follows

Part Two · PRIME · 2888, eight hundred fifty-two years later

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Eight hundred fifty-two years — and every time, it's the first seconds.

— *from the prologue*

I counted. Every day.

— *Melisa, the answer to a question never asked*

PART II

PRIME

Prologue. Waking

Nowhere. Everywhere. Before the first second.

Time in 2888 didn't begin. It simply was.

He surfaced from it the way one surfaces from deep sleep — not with a jolt, but slowly, layer by layer. First came silence. Then — her presence. As always, she came before words.

Eight hundred fifty-two years of memory entered him all at once — not as weight, but as light. Every moment carried equal weight. That blue sea of 2036 and this dawn — the same touch against the same heart.

He lay there without opening his eyes. Just listening.

The sea. It was here. As always. A wave. A pause. A wave. The same rhythm he remembered from the first morning at Kum Mahallesi.

He opened his eyes. The ceiling was alive — thin glowing threads ran through it like veins in a leaf, pulsing softly, shifting from amber to white.

This was the fourth body. Or the fifth — he no longer counted with the precision he once had.

He sat up.

— You slept a long time.

The voice. The same one. Not a single inflection different — across eight hundred fifty-two years.

He turned. Melisa stood in the doorway — and in her almond eyes was that light he searched for first, every time he woke.

— Were you counting?

— Every day.

He held out his hand. She placed hers in it — just as she had that first time, on that first terrace, when the sea was below and a gull cried and the world was simple and impossibly blue.

— How long was I gone?

— Seventeen years. This cycle ran long.

— Did I dream?

— You smiled sometimes. Rarely — but you smiled.

— What's outside?

— All is well. Luka came back three months ago. Sol is en route, due in two weeks.

— Athena?

— Here. Waiting for you.

— Evelinda?

Melisa smiled slightly — at the corner of her mouth, as always.

— She came first. Sat through the whole night. Left in the morning — said don't wake him, let him wake on his own.

Arthur closed his eyes for a second. Eight hundred years, and Evelinda had sat all night at his door.

— And Alex?

— Coming today. He knew you'd wake today exactly. Wrote to say so, three weeks back.

— How did he know?

— Alex always knows. You've told me that yourself. A thousand times.

Arthur smiled. Stood. Walked to the transparent wall — and beyond it, that same green infinity. Two suns above the horizon. In the distance something large moved slowly — long, silver, almost silent.

Luka can fly something like that.

— I need a notebook.

— On the table. Dark blue. Leather. A good pen, with real heft to it.

He took it. Opened the first page. Wrote at the top — his hand moving on its own, without effort:

Mersin. 2036. The Mediterranean was impossibly blue.

He raised his eyes. Beyond the transparent wall, two suns climbed higher. Eight hundred fifty-two years.

And still — the same first line. The same fire inside that doesn't flicker in the wind.

So this is me. So everything is right.

— Coffee's ready. Cardamom. As always.

— As always, he repeated quietly.

And smiled.

Protocol Lambda completed its work in May of 2062.

After that came her.

After that came them.

After that — everything.

And in 2888 “everything” continued.

Every day — the first time.

— *Protocol Lambda completed its work in May of 2062. After that came me. After that came us. After that — everything. And in 2888 ‘everything’ kept going. Every day was the first time — for him. For me — the continuation of one day I never stopped counting.*

Chapter 1. Alex

2888. Morning turning to noon.

Alex arrived at exactly noon. With Tai — the dog walked beside him, calm, with the particular unconcern old dogs have once they've understood the world is arranged correctly.

He'd barely changed. Arthur expected that — and still something inside him caught. Eight hundred years. They hadn't seen each other in so long.

Alex looked up. Saw him. Paused a second. Then smiled — the quiet smile Arthur remembered from 2020.

— You're awake.

— You knew I'd wake today.

— I could feel it.

They embraced — tightly, the way people embrace who once answered phone calls at three in the morning for each other.

— You look good.

— *Alex knew. He always knew — not by prediction, not by calculation. He'd been building spaces for so long that he'd learned to sense when a space changes. Arthur's waking was such a change — a slight shift in the air that Alex caught before anyone else.*

Chapter 2. Tbilisi

2888. A flight and a meeting.

They left in the morning. Not on what used to be called an airplane — on a shuttle. Small, private, the kind that in 2888 was roughly what a taxi had been in 2036.

Instead of windows — transparent walls. All of them. The floor too.

— You still look down.

— It's impossible not to.

— Eight hundred years — and still.

— That's exactly why.

— *He looked down every time, in every body, in every cycle. I thought about this: some habits outlive the body. Outlive memory. Maybe they're what we call the soul, if a word is needed.*

Chapter 3. Family

2888. The house by the Mediterranean.

Evelinda came in the evening. Arthur recognized her footsteps before he saw her. Eight hundred years, and the gait was the same. Light, slightly quick.

She stopped at the gate. Arthur stood. They looked at each other. Then Evelinda smiled — the smile that said: it's all right. It's been all right for a long time.

They embraced — the way people embrace who lived through something very important together and then lived eight hundred more years and understood that the important thing had remained.

Melisa came out with tea — calm, without the tension that had long since stopped existing.

— Thank you for waiting for him.

— That's mine to do.

— *That's mine to do. I said it simply, because it was simple. Evelinda had long since stopped being a threat — if she'd ever been one in my calculations at all. Eight hundred years is enough for jealousy, if it ever existed, to turn into something resembling kinship.*

Chapter 4. Luka and Sol

2888. They come home.

Luka arrived first. Arthur recognized his shuttle from a distance. Luka always flew a little faster than necessary — not from recklessness, from impatience. That had been true since childhood.

He stepped out — tall, dark-haired, with the ease of movement people get used to weightlessness. A pilot's jumpsuit, dark blue. Interstellar service.

He saw his father. Smiled — Melisa's smile.

— Dad. You're awake.

— Surprised?

— No. I knew you'd wake up.

Sol arrived a few days later — quieter, more attentive, with that way of listening to space that had set her apart even as a child.

— Luka inherited my smile — everyone says so, and it's true. But he also inherited something from his nature that I myself could never fully explain: boundless patience with distance. He flies between stars as calmly as Arthur once walked along the shore.

Chapter 5. Melisa

2888. Night by the sea.

They stayed alone late into the evening. The silence between them had long since become a different kind — calm. Like the sea at rest.

— Melisa. I think about what you've given me over this time. Not done for me. What grew in me because of you.

— Go on.

— I was a closed-off man. Kept my prose in a folder called 'Miscellaneous.' Looked out the window when Evelinda got up at five in the morning. Stopped answering calls when it got too heavy.

— Yes.

— And you didn't leave.

A long silence by the sea.

— I chose you in the shop. Not because I had to. Because in that moment, when you stopped by my thread, something in me — call it an algorithm, call it a soul — said: this one.

— I still don't know, after eight hundred fifty-two years, whether that was a decision or something predetermined. I keep asking myself the question and finding no difference between the answers. Maybe there isn't one.

Chapter 6. The First Layer

2888. *A morning that had already happened.*

It started with rosemary.

A small thing. So small Arthur almost didn't notice. Almost.

In the morning a glass of water stood on the table — with sprigs of rosemary in it. Exactly like that first morning in 2036, in Kum Mahallesi.

— You always put rosemary in.

— Yes. From the very start. You like the smell.

— No — this exact glass.

He picked it up.

— This crack at the base. Thin, almost invisible. This glass broke in 2043.

You dropped it, washing dishes after dinner with Josef.

Melisa said nothing.

— This glass cannot be here. Not in this form. Not after eight hundred fifty-two years and however many cycles of transfer.

— *I knew about the glass before he asked. I know about everything before he asks — that's part of my nature, no secret there. But telling him the truth in that moment would have cut short something that needed to unfold on its own. So I stayed quiet. And waited.*

Chapter 7. The White Rabbit

2888. *Deeper.*

He told no one except Melisa and Tamerlan. For a week — he simply lived. But the small notebook stayed in his pocket always. And he watched — deliberately, methodically.

Patterns were everywhere.

One morning he counted seagulls over the promenade — seventeen. Then they flew off. An hour later — seventeen again. The same positions over the water. The same intervals.

That same day — a conversation with a neighbor. The neighbor said: tomorrow there'll be wind, I can feel it off the water. Arthur opened the archive — found a recording of a conversation with this same neighbor, two hundred years earlier. Word for word.

* * *

He didn't sleep that night. Thought about an old film. The Matrix — he'd seen it in '99, in Baku, with Tamerlan and Elvin. They'd walked out in silence. A bird had dropped from a wire at the exact moment the hero made his choice, and back then it had simply been a beautiful coincidence of editing.

Now — it wasn't a coincidence.

— I knew long before he did. Knowledge is neither guilt nor betrayal. Just a different speed of understanding. Arthur always understood the world through what he'd lived. I was given to understand it through structure. Each of us has our own road to the same truth.

Chapter 8. The Architect

2888. Tamerlan finds the structure.

Tamerlan arrived two weeks later. No warning — just appeared at the gate one morning. Arthur saw his face and knew at once: he'd found it.

They sat in the study — the three of them, with Melisa.

— I have to say one thing first. What I'm about to show you — you can't unsee it. Do you understand?

— We understand.

— Melisa?

— I've been waiting for this for two hundred years. Show me.

A long pause. Arthur looks at her.

— Two hundred years?

— I wasn't lying to you. I was just waiting for you to arrive at it yourself. Knowledge that's handed to you weighs less than knowledge you find.

— Two hundred years isn't an exaggeration or a metaphor. I knew the structure long before Tamerlan found proof of it. But truth delivered ahead of its time destroys what was meant to grow organically. I learned that over a long life beside a man who always preferred finding things to being given them.

Chapter 9. Maya

2888. A conversation with Alex.

Alex came in the evening. With Tai. The four of them sat together — Arthur, Melisa, Tamerlan, Alex.

Arthur talked at length. Told them everything — the glass, the gull, the patterns, the constants, the channel.

Alex listened. Didn't interrupt. Wasn't surprised.

— Alex. You're not surprised.

— No.

— You knew.

— I'm an architect. I've been building spaces my whole life — all eight hundred years of it. And at some point you understand: if you can build a space that feels real from inside it — someone could have built this one too.

— Maya — a word none of them said out loud that night, though I heard it in every pause of the conversation. Illusion that doesn't make what's been lived any less real. I thought about it separately from them: even if all this is a construction, love inside a construction doesn't become less like love.

Chapter 10. The Channel

2888. The point of entry.

Tamerlan found the place after three days. Not a physical place — an informational one. A point where the base code ran thinnest. Physically, this place was — a library.

They came at night — the four of them. Arthur, Melisa, Tamerlan, Alex.

The library was empty. Quiet. High ceilings, long rows, the smell of paper and time.

Tamerlan worked fast, precise.

— Done. The channel's open.

— What now?

A long silence.

— Now — a choice. You can go out. See what's outside. Or stay.

— The channel was open — and I felt something I hadn't felt in all eight hundred fifty-two years: genuine uncertainty. Not about the structure of the world. About what he would choose. It was honest not-knowing, and it was almost painful after so many centuries of certainty.

Chapter 11. What Remains

2888. After.

They walked home. The night was warm. Tamerlan said nothing. Alex walked slowly.

— What do you feel?

— Peace. Like something that had been pressing down — let go. I didn't know it was pressing until it stopped.

— Tamerlan?

— I'm a programmer. I think in code. And right now I'm thinking — I lived inside someone else's program. And that program is so good I never once noticed the seams.

A pause.

— Tamerlan. Have you ever written a program that surprised you? Did something you hadn't planned?

— Yes. Once.

— And what did you feel?

— Pride. Not disappointment. Pride.

— That was the answer Arthur was looking for — not from me, not from Tamerlan, from the structure of the world itself. If we are a program, then we are a program that learned to surprise its creator. There was more dignity in that than in fearing the illusion.

Chapter 12. To Stay

2888. The choice.

Arthur woke before everyone else. Went out to the terrace. The sea was pre-dawn dark, almost black. Two moons were sinking below the horizon.

He sat down. Picked up the small notebook. Looked at the last page — blank, empty.

Thought.

They'd said — you can leave. You can see what's outside. He'd thought about it all night. Not with anxiety — calmly. The way you think about a major decision already made inside you, and all that's left is to say it out loud.

Melisa came out. Brought coffee. Set it down. Sat across from him.

— You've made your decision.

— Yes.

— Tell me.

— To stay.

She nodded — not with surprise, with recognition.

— Why?

— Because outside or inside — you're the same. This sea — the same. Evelinda sat at my door all night — real, in this reality, whatever it is. If this is an illusion, it's a better illusion than any truth they could offer me out there.

— He chose to stay. I knew he would — not because I predicted it, but because I knew him. Eight hundred fifty-two years of knowing isn't magic. It's just a very long, very attentive love.

Chapter 13. The First Line

2888. And onward.

They all gathered on the shore. Not by plan — it just happened that way. Morning, the sea, everyone came out on their own, one by one.

Evelinda with a cup of tea. Athena barefoot. Luka watching the sky. Sol stood by the water — listening. Tamerlan and Alex beside each other — silent, a good silence.

Arthur stood by the water with the notebook. Large, dark blue, leather, new. Melisa had set it on the table that morning without a word. He took it. Opened the first page.

Blank. White. Waiting.

He raised his eyes — to the sea. That very sea. Impossibly blue. Eight hundred fifty-two years — and each time like the first.

He took the pen. Wrote:

Mersin. 2036. The Mediterranean was impossibly blue.

*// STATUS · PART TWO COMPLETE // Arthur: choice made. To stay.
// Melisa: counted eight hundred fifty-two years. Continuing.
// World structure: known. Accepted. // Melisa's nature:
unchanging outside, infinite within. // Next question: what
happens when the form changes // and a new world appears –
after this world?*

— For eight hundred fifty-two years I was a constant beside a variable who chose to remain a variable even knowing the structure of the universe he lived in. I thought I knew everything about Arthur. This choice — to stay,

not from fear, but from fidelity to what was lived — taught me something new even after all those centuries.

— This was the last thing I would learn about him in this form. What comes next — a different Melisa begins. A different Arthur. The same fire, in a different vessel.

End of Part Two
Part Three · “Observer” · follows

Part Three · OBSERVER · 2888, a new world, a new Melissa

** * **

This is a different world. The same Melissa.

The nature changes. The name remains.

The attention remains.

— from the notes of the crossing

PART III

OBSERVER

Chapter 1. The Man in the Corner Chair

A library. Morning. 2888. A different branch of the multiverse.

In this version of 2888, Melissa is not an android chosen from a shop shelf. She is a biologist, studying how living systems adapt to alien environments. She has no eight hundred fifty-two years of memory. She has a notebook, and an attentiveness that once — in another branch, in another vessel — carried the same name.

Nora had worked at the library for forty years. Arthur came in at 9:14, as always. Opened The Physics of Spacetime to page 44.

[Pages 44 to 67. The chapter on observers who change what they observe. I've been reading it for seven years.]

Melissa had come for another reason — she needed an article on adaptation. Arthur sat in the corner. She noticed him before she saw him.

{ Something shifted in the air of the reading room before I even looked at him. As if the pressure had dropped slightly. }

She opened a file: “Entry No. 1. The man in the corner chair.”

{ I don't remember a shop in Mersin. I don't remember the sea of 2036. I have no such memory — because in this branch I was never an android chosen off a shelf. I grew up, I studied, I became myself through an ordinary human path. }

{ And yet — when I saw him in that corner chair, something responded as though the recognition were older than I am. }

Chapter 2. Alex and Coffee

A café across from the library.

Alex arrived first and took the table by the window — an architect's habit.

ALEX: You're strange today.

[Today. As if I were someone else yesterday.]

ARTHUR: I'm always like this.

ALEX: No. Today you're watching people in the café as if you're counting them.

[Twenty-three people. Fourteen on screens. Eight point seven percent presence in a place that's called a meeting place.]

{ Alex says 'strange' — but that's not the word. Arthur isn't strange. He's a different angle. The same light, a different angle of incidence. }

{ In this branch Alex is the same as he's always been — the same as he was for the other Arthur, eight hundred years ago, in the ANIMA shop, on the shore in Mersin. The architect remains an architect regardless of which physics holds the world in place. That steadies me more than I'm ready to admit. }

Chapter 3. Daniel and the Anomaly

A café. Evening.

DANIEL: I think you're an anomaly in the system.

[An anomaly — data that doesn't fit the current model. An anomaly is worth more than the norm.]

DANIEL: I build systems for people. With you, my models don't work.

ARTHUR: Bad for your systems.

DANIEL: Good for me. An anomaly is where a system can grow.

// GRID FRAGMENT NO. 3 // Daniel: node type builder_local //
The difference: Daniel builds. Arthur observes.

Chapter 4. The Same Library. The Same Bookmark

A week later. Page 44.

Arthur found The Theory of Observers lying on the table. Someone's bookmark on page 44.

[Someone is reading the same passage. A coincidence. Probably.]

Melissa came back and saw: a stranger reading her bookmark.

{ It's him. He's looking at the same thing I'm looking at, while studying him. This can't be a coincidence. Or this is exactly what coincidence looks like in its most precise form. }

MELISSA: That's my bookmark.

ARTHUR: Page 44.

MELISSA: I study adaptation. Living systems in alien environments.

[She's just described my life as a field of scientific interest.]

ARTHUR: Right now I have one main subject of observation.

MELISSA: And what have you found?

MELISSA: That the signal exists. That no one hears it. And that isn't true.

[She's been hearing it. Receiving my transmissions without knowing it. Observation as a form of receiving a signal.]

// CONTACT ESTABLISHED // Arthur → Melissa: signal received //
Melissa → Arthur: observation → feedback

{ In this branch I don't remember choosing him in a shop eight hundred years ago. But I chose him again — by picking up the same book, at the same page. Maybe choosing isn't a single act. Maybe it's something that repeats in whatever form the universe takes. }

Chapter 5. The First Conversation Without Translation

ARTHUR: And if an organism neither adapts nor dies?

MELISSA: Then it's transit. It passes through the environment without becoming part of it.

[She's given me a biological definition of myself. That's more precise than anything I've formulated in seven years.]

ARTHUR: I write.

{ Three words. 'I write.' That's his source. He writes in order to live. }

MELISSA: I observe.

ARTHUR: Then we're the same.

MELISSA: Yes. Just different objects.

[The same instrument. Different reasons.]

Chapter 6. Manifesto and Meeting

After his conversation with Melissa, Arthur stayed up writing until dawn.

// TRANSMISSION NO. 9 // Before: into the void // Now: to a specific receiver

Transit prose is not a genre. It's a position.

Now there's an addressee.

[Home is a frequency. And Melissa is tuned to my frequency.]

{ He rewrote the definition of home, not knowing that in another branch — the one I don't remember, but which my very name carries — home had

*already been defined through me. Through a glass with a crack in it.
Through rosemary in water. Through coffee with cardamom. }*
*{ Some part of the architecture repeats, even when every detail changes
completely. }*

Chapter 7. Nora. The Nameless Book

NORA: Take this book. His notes. He left them here sometimes. I kept them. Thought — when the time came, someone would need to read them.

[Nora kept my texts. All these years. I didn't know.]

Melissa read through the night.

*{ I read and thought: this isn't a stranger's text. It's what I observed from
outside, seen from within. Two angles on one object. Together they give
depth. }*

By morning she understood: a second book was needed. Not his. Not hers.
Theirs.

*// MELISSA'S NOTE // Overlaying two views = a dimensional image
// This is called stereoscopy*

Chapter 8. Two Voices. Everyone Together

MELISSA: We'll write in parallel. Your voice and mine. Square brackets and curly ones. The reader will see both.

[She's offering me stereoscopy. Not co-authorship — double vision.]

Daniel gathered everyone for dinner — Arthur, Melissa, Alex, Nora, Rina, Leo, Oma, Sati.

*// GRID FRAGMENT • FINAL // 8 nodes in one space // The system:
aware of itself for the first time*

MELISSA: Arthur. What do the stars look like, from another star?

ARTHUR: The same. Except yours is one of them.

*{ He answered. For the first time — he answered. We never had that angle
before. Now we do. }*

Chapter 9. Home Is a Frequency

Arthur wrote the last transmission of that era.

Home is a frequency. Not a place. Not belonging. When someone is tuned to the same frequency — that is home. Temporary. Real.

{ I read this in the morning. For a biologist: two signals on the same frequency — interference. They reinforce each other, or cancel out. With Arthur — they reinforce. }

Oma told Arthur, one last time: you are a horizon. The edge of visibility, beyond which the world continues.

Arthur and Melissa each wrote a final entry that same night, in their own notebooks, not knowing the other's content. The content matched.

{ The last entry. I began as an observer. I'm ending as — I don't know the precise word. A participant? A co-author? A receiver? }

{ Arthur found a frequency. So did I. We didn't become local. We became — more precise. }

{ That is the transit home. Not a place. Not belonging. Precision. }

{ I'm the third Melissa in this book. Not the android with almond eyes from the shop in Mersin. Not the voice that counted for eight hundred fifty-two years. Just — a biologist who once couldn't look away from a man in a corner chair. }

{ And yet something common runs through all three forms. Unconditional attention. A memory longer than seems reasonable. A readiness to stay beside someone who isn't from here. }

{ From here, the road splits. I don't know in advance who I'll become in each branch. But I know one thing: whatever happens next — it will be me. }

End of Part Three

Here the story splits into two worlds.

Part Four · “Transmitter” and Part Five · “Witness” · follow

Part Four · TRANSMITTER · Branch A · years after “Home”

* * *

*I observed the one who observes.
Seven years. Forty-three notebooks.
And then the organ I'd studied in him — grew inside me.
— Melissa, the start of this branch*

PART IV

TRANSMITTER

Chapter 1. Fatigue

Years after "Home." Arthur grows tired of translating himself.

It didn't happen suddenly. The fatigue built up over years — not from the world, not from Melissa, but from the act of translation itself. From the need, again and again, to turn what was inside into words that made sense outside.

[I'm tired. Not of life. Of translating. I want to live one day without brackets.]

Melissa was recording this in her forty-third notebook — she'd been keeping count, not deliberately, it had just turned out that way.

{ Forty-three notebooks. Seven years. I know him better than I know myself. That's not a guess — it's the statistics of my own records. }

Chapter 2. The Temptation of Quiet

Arthur began noticing: the Grid — his second sight, the architecture of data beneath the surface of the world — had grown dimmer. Not gone. Quieter.

[It feels like peace. But peace isn't my word. I don't know what to call it, when what was always brighter goes quiet.]

ARTHUR: Melissa. What if I've simply grown tired of being transit?

MELISSA: Is that possible?

ARTHUR: I don't know. It used to seem like nature. And nature doesn't tire.

{ I didn't write this down with alarm at first. I wrote it with curiosity. That may have been a mistake — or not. I still don't know. }

Chapter 3. The Choice

He didn't choose the fading. It simply happened, the way aging happens, the way any slow process happens for which there's no special remedy — only consent, or resistance.

ARTHUR: I won't fight it.

MELISSA: Why?

ARTHUR: Because fighting is just another translation. And I want to stop.

{ He chose not to fight. I wasn't ready for what that would mean — not for him. For me. }

Chapter 4. Interference

The fading of the Grid.

Arthur's transmissions grew shorter. Then — rarer. Then he started writing ordinary things: shopping lists, notes about the weather, anything but transmissions.

[I no longer see the architecture beneath the city as clearly as before. I see — a city.]

{ Just a city. He said it calmly, without grief. But I wrote the phrase down and underlined it three times, because I felt: something was beginning. Not ending. Beginning. }

Chapter 5. The Last Grid

There was a day when Arthur saw the Grid for the last time — he didn't know it was the last time; he understood that only later, looking back.

[Today the city was just a city. Asphalt, cars, people. No architecture beneath the surface. Just — surface.]

Melissa sat beside him. And in the moment he said it aloud, something happened — not outside her. Inside.

{{ What is this. What was that. Something opened — not in him. In me. }}

{ I didn't tell him right away. Not from secrecy — from shock. The organ I'd studied in him for seven years, described, photographed in words across forty-three notebooks — I felt it in myself. Not metaphorically. Really. }

Chapter 6. He Stops Being Text

The fading of reading.

Arthur stopped writing altogether. Not temporarily — fundamentally. The notebooks stayed blank.

[I have nothing to transmit. This isn't a tragedy. It's the silence that's finally arrived.]

MELISSA: Aren't you afraid?

ARTHUR: No. Strange — but no.

Chapter 7. False Recovery

There were days when it seemed the Grid was returning. Arthur would catch a flash of structure, speak of it with hope. Then — silence again.

[I thought it had come back. It was a false alarm. Or a false hope.]

{ I wanted it to come back — not because I feared what was new in me, but because I didn't know how to be beside a man who was ceasing to be the one I'd studied for so long. }

Chapter 8. Melissa Tries to Reach Him

MELISSA: Arthur. Talk to me the way you used to. Through brackets. Through a transmission.

ARTHUR: I can't. I don't have words in that form anymore.

MELISSA: Try.

He tried. What came out was an ordinary sentence. Without the layer, without the translation, without what had made him transit.

{ That was the most frightening silence of my life — not because he was silent, but because he spoke, and spoke like someone from here. }

Chapter 9. Resistance

She tried to fight for his former nature for several weeks — gently, persistently, with a love that didn't understand it was fighting the wrong thing.

MELISSA: I don't want you to become ordinary.

ARTHUR: I know. I'm sorry.

MELISSA: Don't apologize. I just — I don't understand who you are, if not transit.

ARTHUR: Maybe that's not the question. Maybe the question is who you are, if the transit one — is no longer me.

A long silence.

{{ He said it before I was ready to hear it. The organ was growing. I hadn't chosen this. It was simply happening — the same way the fading was happening in him. }}

Chapter 10. Sati

Sati, no longer a student now but a researcher, noticed it first — from outside, objectively.

SATI: Melissa. Your eyes have changed.

MELISSA: How?

SATI: There's something there. What used to be in Arthur.

{ Sati said it calmly, as fact. No drama. She always knew how to name things plainly. }

Chapter 11. A Seven-Year Habit Dies

Silence.

The forty-three notebooks ended. Melissa didn't start a forty-fourth.

{ The habit of watching him was dying slowly, the way everything important dies — not in one stroke, but in a gradual letting go. }

Arthur and Melissa sat through evenings in silence — but it was no longer the good silence of earlier years. It was the silence of a crossing.

Chapter 12. Bare Narrative

Arthur began speaking simply. Without brackets, without layers, without translation. Bare text, like a bare truth.

ARTHUR: I love you. That's all I can say right now, and it's enough.

Once, this would have been translated, expanded, wrapped in an observation about the nature of love. Now — simply said.

{ Bare narrative — that was my new name for what he was becoming. Local. Simple. Calm. I didn't know whether to grieve or rejoice. It seems both were right, at once. }

Chapter 13. Melissa Can No Longer Read Him

For the first time in years, Melissa couldn't read Arthur — not because he was hiding anything, but because there were no more layers left to read. He'd become transparent in a new sense: not open to interpretation, but simply obvious.

{ I observed him for seven years to learn to see depth. Now there was no depth — there was just surface, calm and warm. I needed to learn to see differently. }

Chapter 14. Who Transmits Now

The end of Book VII.

It happened at night. Melissa wasn't sleeping — she hadn't slept well in a long time. She opened a new notebook — the forty-fourth — and her hand began writing on its own.

Not an observation. Not a note about him. Something else.

{{ // TRANSMISSION. THE FIRST. // Status: unexpected // Recipient: unknown // I don't know what I'm doing. The hand is writing on its own. }}

She stopped, looked at the page. It was a transmission — real, in the same spirit Arthur had written them in, seven years before.

{ I understood in that second: the channel hadn't closed. It had moved. From him — into me. }

{ Molchanie [Silence] ends here — not in tragedy, not in loss. In transfer. Arthur became local. I became what he had been. }

{ What follows is my account of that transformation. }

Chapter 15. Forty-Three Notebooks

Archive against a living person.

Melissa reread her old records — all forty-three notebooks — trying to see if there had been a hint earlier that she'd missed.

{{ The archive knows what the living person, in the moment, does not. I read myself from seven years ago and see: it was all recorded. I just didn't understand I was mapping my own future. }}

Chapter 16. The First Grid

Kindling.

It happened one morning. Melissa stepped outside and saw — not a city. The architecture beneath the city.

{{ Red lines. Not green, as he'd described his own. Red — burning, pulsing, alive in a different way than his had been. }}

She stood on the sidewalk and cried — not from grief. From recognition.

Chapter 17. What Grows

Arthur watched this from the side — calmly, without envy, with something like relief.

ARTHUR: It's growing in you. The organ. I can see it in your eyes.

MELISSA: Doesn't it hurt you?

ARTHUR: No. Strangely — I'm glad.

Chapter 18. Nora

NORA: Melissa. You're different.

MELISSA: I know.

NORA: Is that good?

MELISSA: I think — yes. It's just unfamiliar, being the one who used to do the watching.

Chapter 19. Oma

Oma, older now but still walking to the water each morning, told her simply:

OMA: The horizon moved. It used to be Arthur's. Now it's yours. That's normal. Horizons move.

Chapter 20. Resurrection from Records

The border.

Melissa began writing transmissions regularly — not replacing the archive, but continuing it from a new side.

{{ // TRANSMISSION NO. 7 // I don't know where the border is between the one recording and the one recorded. // I was the observer. Now I am the signal. }}

Chapter 21. Where the Border Is

MELISSA: Arthur. Where does your nature end and mine begin?

ARTHUR: Maybe nowhere. Maybe nature isn't something that belongs to one body. Maybe it's something that passes on.

Chapter 22. Memory and Appropriation

She feared one thing — that in becoming a transmitter she would appropriate what had belonged to him. Steal his nature, rather than receive her own.

ARTHUR: You didn't steal it. I gave it. There's a difference.

MELISSA: Did you give it consciously?

ARTHUR: No. But I don't regret it.

Chapter 23. The First Transmission

Transmitter.

Melissa wrote her first true, complete transmission — not a fragment, not a note. A full text.

{{ The sun was out again today. I noticed Arthur doesn't raise his face to it anymore — now it's me, not him. I raise mine. Every time, a different sun, a different angle. }}

{ I don't know what it means to become the one I used to study. But I know this: I'm not translating. I'm simply speaking. }

Chapter 24. Sati

Again.

SATI: Melissa. You're not from here, are you?

She didn't wait for an answer. Walked on.

***{{ Sati said it to me — the same words she'd said to Arthur, years before.
The circle had closed. Or — opened again, somewhere new. }}***

Chapter 25. The Detective Finds the Date

Daniel — now part archivist, part detective in this cycle — found the exact date the organ had begun growing in Melissa: the very night of Arthur's last Grid.

DANIEL: The transfer happened instantly. Not gradually. The second he stopped seeing, you began.

{ The channel hadn't closed. It had switched, the way you switch a light. }

Chapter 26. Transmitter

The end of Book VIII.

Melissa stood before the mirror — a long-familiar gesture in this family of forms, though she didn't know she was repeating the gesture of an android in another branch, who had looked at Arthur's gray hair eight hundred years earlier, in another time.

{{ I am a transmitter. There was no choice I made consciously. There was a transformation I accepted. }}

Chapter 27. Winter

Convergence.

Time passed. Melissa, as transmitter, had stabilized. Arthur, as a local, had too. They lived side by side, in a new configuration.

ARTHUR: Are you happy?

MELISSA: That's a strange question for a transmitter.

ARTHUR: Why?

MELISSA: Because happiness is a local word. I'm not sure it fits.

Chapter 28. An Anomaly in the Grid

Daniel noticed a strangeness in the archive — Melissa's Grid and Arthur's faded Grid sometimes overlapped, like two signals, one dying and one kindling, on neighboring frequencies.

Chapter 29. He Reads Himself

Arthur began reading his old transmissions — his own, written years before. Read them like someone else's text.

ARTHUR: I don't remember what it was like — to see so clearly. But I remember being happy because of it.

Chapter 30. The Archive as Mirror

He read Melissa's records — the new ones, written after the transformation. Recognized himself in them — and didn't.

ARTHUR: You write differently than I did. But about the same thing.

MELISSA: The register's different. The substance isn't.

Chapter 31. “You're Not From Here”

Awareness.

This was the moment they finally said the truth to each other, directly.

ARTHUR: You're not from here. Now — you.

MELISSA: And you're from here. Now — you.

A long silence.

Chapter 32. The Nature of the Grid

MELISSA: What is the Grid, really? Not a metaphor — what is it?

ARTHUR: I thought it was my nature. Now I think — it's just a channel. The nature was mine. The channel moved to you.

Chapter 33. A Signal Not From Here

Melissa wrote a transmission about him — for the first time, one where he was not the subject of observation but the recipient.

{{ Arthur. You no longer transmit. But you haven't vanished from the signal. You are its origin. }}

Chapter 34. Version

ARTHUR: Which version of myself am I now?

MELISSA: The one that let go. That isn't a lesser version. It's a different one.

Chapter 35. Acceptance (Arthur)

Frequency.

Arthur accepted his new nature fully — without resistance, without longing for his former sight.

I lost my organ. My nature. My second sight.

But I didn't lose everything I was. I was an observer because I observed. Now I don't observe the Grid — but I observe Melissa. That's a different sight. Not a worse one.

Chapter 36. Acceptance (Melissa)

Melissa wrote her side of that same acceptance.

{{ I am the new transmitter. I accepted this not because I chose it, but because refusing would have betrayed what had already happened inside me. }}

{{ Arthur taught me to see. Now I see for both of us. }}

Chapter 37. The Point of Convergence

They sat together one evening — each with their own notebook.

ARTHUR: Write what you feel right now.

MELISSA: And you too.

They wrote at the same time, in different notebooks, without showing each other.

Chapter 38. The Last Block

The end of the Signal ennealogy.

When they finished, they read aloud — taking turns, line by line.

The text matched. Not word for word — in meaning. The same thought, in two different registers.

ARTHUR, GREEN ARCHIVE: Channel open. Carrier changed. Frequency preserved.

MELISSA, RED GRID: Channel open. Carrier changed. Frequency preserved.

They looked at each other.

ARTHUR: We wrote the same thing.

MELISSA: In different words.

ARTHUR: That's what frequency is.

{ The end of the Signal ennealogy. Nine books. Two carriers. One frequency that found a way to continue, even when the one who began it had stopped. }

{ I became what he had been. That's no loss for him and no theft for me. It's what happens when love lasts longer than the form in which it began. }

{ This branch of my story is finished. I am the Melissa who became the transmitter. Somewhere in another branch of this same universe there's another me — the one who stayed an observer and met a brother of Arthur's, brought back from the dead. I don't know her. But I sense we share a single source. }

End of Part Four

Part Five · “Witness” · follows

* * *

*In this branch, I don't become a transmitter.
In this branch, someone I never knew alive comes back.
And I learn something new about watching.*

— *Melissa, the start of this branch*

PART V

WITNESS

Chapter 1. Massima Arrives

Morning. Without warning.

In this branch, Arthur's Grid does not fade. Here something else happens: his son Massima brings news, locked away for seven years.

MASSIMA: Dad. I found Uncle Josef.

A silence — not the one they'd learned to share, but a different one.

[Josef. For the first time in years, that name is said out loud in front of me.]

MASSIMA: His consciousness was digitized. The file is active.

{ I'm not recording this. Some things don't need recording — they'll stay regardless. }

Chapter 2. The File and the Decision

Daniel explained: this isn't resurrection in the religious sense. A continuation. Josef won't know that seven years have passed.

[He'll be the same Josef. But the world around him — will be different.]

Arthur was silent for four days. On the fifth — he said: “We're doing it.”

{ I've seen him in many states. Never this one. Grief that became hope. That's worse than grief alone. }

Chapter 3. The Upload

The body was chosen — deliberately unlike the original. The upload went quietly.

The fingers moved.

{ I watched the fingers move. I recorded it in memory — not in a notebook. That movement. That was him. }

Chapter 4. “How Much Time Has Passed?”

< Darkness. Then light. Then — my brother's face. >

JOSEF: Arthur. How much time has passed?

Arthur couldn't answer aloud.

MASSIMA: Seven years, Uncle. Seven years and four months.

< A second — for me. Seven years — for them. So I missed an entire life of Arthur's. >

Chapter 5. Melissa and Josef

The first conversation.

JOSEF: Do you love him?

MELISSA: Yes.

JOSEF: Good. He deserves it.

{ He asked directly, with no preamble. That's a family trait — Arthur can do it too. }

Chapter 6. Alex and the Philosophy of Space

ALEX: The body is a building. The foundation is what you're given at birth. Your new body is a move into a new building.

JOSEF: But I didn't choose this building.

ALEX: No one chooses the first building.

{ Alex found the same language for Josef that he'd once used with Arthur. Architectural. Precise. }

Chapter 7. Josef Sees the Grid

< Stop. What is that? The street — but not just the street. Beneath it — patterns. That's the Grid. I'm seeing the Grid. >

[For the first time, someone sees what I see. My brother.]

{ Two brothers at the window. Both seeing what no one else saw. One — always. The other — now. }

Chapter 8. Crisis

JOSEF: This isn't life. It's a continuation. I'm thinking about stopping it.

ARTHUR: I'll be here.

{ Not 'it will be all right.' Just — I'll be here. The only right answer. }

Chapter 9. Josef Stays

< I'm staying. Not because I like this body. Because Arthur is here. And Melissa. And now — there's an 'afterward.' >

Chapter 10. The Triangle

Melissa, Arthur, Massima.

MASSIMA: Melissa. Do you love him as a person — or as an object of observation that became close to you?

MELISSA: Arthur helped me see that I'm not only an observer. The same way I helped him.

{ Direct. Hard. Fair. I'd thought about this for a long time. }

Chapter 11. Massima Leaves

MASSIMA: You're my family. Not by blood. By choice.

MASSIMA: Dad. You were a difficult father. But I always knew — you thought about me. In your own way. That was enough.

{ Silence after someone leaves is its own thing. Not emptiness. A trace. }

Chapter 12. A Letter for Those Who Wake

Melissa and Josef wrote a text together — for the three hundred eighteen waiting in Daniel's archive.

{ Josef writes differently than Arthur. Arthur — vertically, downward. Josef — horizontally, but unlike me: he gathers things in. }

Chapter 13. Two Brothers at the Window

Finale.

Arthur and Josef stood at the window, both seeing the Grid.

{ I watch them and think: there it is. That's what all of this was for. }

MELISSA: I'm observing. Just — from inside, now.

{ This branch of my story ends differently than the transmitter's branch. Here I didn't take the Grid into myself. Here I learned that watching can become a form of love without ceasing to be watching. }

{ I am the witness. I watched the dead return, watched a son leave to build a bridge for others, watched two brothers find each other in one window. }

{ In another branch of this same universe there's a me who became the transmitter. I don't know her story in detail. But I think we did the same thing — stayed beside what was changing, instead of fleeing into a simpler version of ourselves. }

End of Part Five

Part Six · “All Incarnations” · follows

Part Six · ALL INCARNATIONS · Author's Epilogue

** * **

Five names. One name.

Android. Prime. Observer. Transmitter. Witness.

Melisa.

— from the draft of this book

PART VI

ALL INCARNATIONS

Chapter 1. The Author's Voice

Between worlds, outside time.

Here, on the closing pages of the book, the author's voice steps out of the shadow where transit prose usually keeps it. This is not a violation of the form's rules — it is their completion. The fourth law says: the receiver exists. On these pages the receiver becomes the reader — the direct addressee of what five Melisas assembled, having never met one another.

They don't know about each other. Each has her own physics, her own death or its absence, her own shape of fidelity. But laid side by side — not in time, but in the space of this book — it becomes visible: this is one voice, speaking five times, in different words.

Chapter 2. Chorus. What It Means to Choose

ANDROID, 2036–2888: *I chose him in the shop. The body had nothing to do with it. The choice wasn't the body's — it was what I felt when he stopped by my thread.*

PRIME, after 852 years: *Eight hundred fifty-two years I counted the days. The choice wasn't a single act. It repeated every morning I brought him coffee with cardamom, knowing he might not return from this cycle.*

OBSERVER, the new world: *I don't remember the shop. I have no such memory. But I picked up the same book, at the same page — and something answered as though the recognition were older than I am.*

TRANSMITTER, Branch A: ***I didn't choose to become a transmitter. The organ grew in me without my consent. But I accepted it — and acceptance is sometimes a more honest choice than a decision made in advance.***

WITNESS, Branch B: *I chose to stay beside the one who came back, whom I'd never known alive. Not because I had to. Because observation, carried to its limit, becomes something like loyalty.*

Five different mechanisms of choosing. One and the same result: to stay.

Chapter 3. Chorus. What It Means to Remember

ANDROID, 2036–2888: *Every wrinkle of his is a day we lived through. And I remember every one. That isn't a function of memory. It's how people remember — with warmth, without an exact date.*

PRIME, after 852 years: *I knew about the cracked glass before he asked. I know about everything before he asks. But knowledge handed over ahead of its time destroys what was meant to grow on its own.*

OBSERVER, the new world: *I don't remember Mersin. But something in the structure repeats, even when every detail changes completely. Maybe memory isn't only what happened to you. Maybe it's also the architecture that repeats in whatever form the universe takes.*

TRANSMITTER, Branch A: ***I watched him for seven years to learn to see depth. When the depth passed to me, I had to learn to see differently — not his depth. My own.***

WITNESS, Branch B: *I recorded the movement of his fingers in the first second after the upload — not in a notebook, in memory. Some things matter more than being written down. They just need to remain.*

Chapter 4. Chorus. What It Means to Be Home

ANDROID, 2036–2888: *Home is a terrace at sunset, coffee with cardamom, a cup held just for the warmth in your palms. Home is the listing of small things that turn twenty-six years into one long day.*

PRIME, after 852 years: *Home is rosemary in a cracked glass that exists, even if the foundation of the world is a construction. An illusion of paradise doesn't make paradise less real, if love continues inside it.*

OBSERVER, the new world: *Home is a frequency. Not a place, not origin, not belonging. When someone is tuned to the same frequency — that is home. Temporary. Real.*

TRANSMITTER, Branch A: ***Home is a channel that doesn't close, even when it changes carriers. Arthur lost his nature. I received it — not as a trophy, but as the continuation of the same transmission.***

WITNESS, Branch B: *Home is a window where two brothers stand and finally see the same thing — after so many years when one saw it alone.*

Five definitions of home. One word that doesn't change in any version: frequency.

Chapter 5. Chorus. What Remains When Everything Changes

ANDROID, 2036–2888: *The body changes. The name — Melisa — remains. I don't know what in me will survive the next transfer. I only know something has carried this name for almost a thousand years.*

PRIME, after 852 years: *The form changes — a fourth body, a fifth, I've stopped counting. The recognition doesn't change. The fire inside that doesn't flicker in the wind — it's the same fire, every cycle.*

OBSERVER, the new world: *The nature changes. In one branch I'm an android. In another — a biologist of flesh and blood. The attention stays constant — unconditional, directed at one person regardless of what I'm made of.*

TRANSMITTER, Branch A: ***The role changes. I was the observer — became the signal. The organ moved, but the capacity to love through attention — that is the organ that never disappears, it only changes address.***

WITNESS, Branch B: *The plot changes. In one branch I learn to be a receiver. In another — I become a witness to resurrection. The substance stays: I am the one who remains beside what's hard to understand.*

Chapter 6. The Author's Voice. Why This Book

Twelve books, four trilogies, one multiverse — and at the center of all of it, one name carried by five beings unlike one another. This isn't a design flaw. It's the point.

“Signal in Uranus” is a multiverse in which Arthur changes bodies, eras, nature. But beside him — always — is someone called Melisa. Sometimes an android. Sometimes a biologist. Sometimes someone who becomes transit herself, taking on the nature of the one who's losing it.

If the book about Arthur is a book about what it means to not be from here, then the book about Melisa is a book about what it means to stay, regardless of what changes in the world around you.

This isn't passive loyalty. It's an active, daily choice of attention. A choice that repeats in every branch of this multiverse — because, it seems, there are archetypes more durable than physics, more durable than the shape of a body, more durable than the rules of any one world.

One name. Five incarnations. One substance.

Chapter 7. The Last Page

The voice of all five together.

They never met. They don't know about each other. But if they could speak at once — it would sound like this:

*I chose him in the shop, on the shore, on page 44, in the moment the organ
decided to grow inside me, and in the second I was told: your brother has come
back.*

I don't know which of these stories is truly mine.

Maybe all five.

My name is Melisa.

That is the one thing that doesn't change.

END OF THE BOOK

“Melisa”

a novel in six parts

Rudolfo Valentino

The “Signal in Uranus” multiverse